took place in Rajasthan and then in Andhra Pradesh, but it took a few months to get over the teething problems. The DBT trials were, in fact, ushered in by the Congress a few months before even the banking system moved to accepting Aadhaar numbers for paperless Know Your Customer verification through UIDAI in September 2013.[9] However, initial feedback on the early experiments was not great. By the time many of the issues identified in these trials were fixed, the Congress had lost the elections and the BJP had come to power in 2014.

The Modi government inherited a structure for DBT transfers in 2014 that had already gone through the testing phase, with several schemes and the backend tech stack in place to build on with Aadhaar. Modi gave the initiative full political backing. To its credit, the new government doubled down on DBTs and expanded it fifteen-fold to 434 schemes by 2018-19.[10] Government data shows that the initial 10.8 crore beneficiaries of DBT reported in 2013-14 (many of whom were added under UPA) went up by seven times to 76.3 crore beneficiary accounts by 2018-19. Actual direct cash payments into people's bank accounts went up by over twenty-nine times from ₹7,367 crore in 2013-14 to ₹2.14 lakh crore in 2018-19. If you add transfers in kind, then total transfers went up by forty-four times in the same period (see Table 4.1).

Table 4.1: DBT Transfers Grew at a Fast Pace in NDA-1: DBT Transfers (2013-14 to 2019-20)